PEACE AND WAR

In the age of sail, life on board ship was harsh as a matter of course. Crews suffered heavy losses, even in peacetime, to disease, accident, fire, and weather. In many ways life on ships was chaotic. Often, for example, there were children on board, as well as farm animals to provide food. Ratings had no uniforms and on many ships neither did officers. Yet by the 18th century, a well-run warship could equally be regarded, by contemporary standards, as a model of organization and efficiency—the regular processes of navigation, the handling of the sails, the keeping of watches, the maintenance of cleanliness, and frequent gunnery drill. The experience of sea combat, although infrequent, was intense by any standards. Broadside duels were bloody affairs, ships battering one another at close range with their cannon while sailors and marines with muskets fired down onto the enemy's deck from the rigging. Amid scenes of unutterable carnage, traditional principles of honorable conduct were maintained. Officers disdained to take cover, standing at great risk on the exposed quarterdeck. The convention of striking colors—lowering the flags—to signal surrender put a limit to the sufferings of a defeated crew, although honor dictated that a captain should not "strike" until his ship was a shambles. Surrender was usually conducted with great ceremony, the defeated commander handing his sword to his victorious opponent who would formally return it to its owner with a few polite words of respect. Such ceremonies took place on blood-spattered decks strewn with the dead.



BATTLE TACTICS

Naval engagements fought by sail were always subject to the influence of the wind, which could change direction, rise, or drop altogether in the course of a battle, confounding planned maneuvers. A contrary wind might trap a fleet in harbor or prevent an entire division from joining a combat in which their comrades were hotly engaged within sight of them. The ships that held the weather gage were well situated to attack—it was the position the British always preferred. The slow movement of the ships meant that hours passed between sighting an enemy and opening fire. Once an engagement started, the fighting was usually quite static for long periods, with opposing ships sometimes locked together or even anchored opposite one another. Rowing boats might be sent from ship to ship around a fleet in battle carrying messages. Until the mid-17th century, tactics involved little more than a scrimmage in which fleets might show a greater or lesser inclination for boarding or for reliance on firepower. The adoption of the line of battle brought more order into naval combat, but no less savagery as each ship chose an enemy to set alongside and duel with. Although its formality could appear stultifying, fighting in line allowed for aggressive maneuvers such as sailing around the enemy van to trap ships between two fires. In the 18th century more adventurous commanders used variants on line tactics such as the "general pursuit" and "breaking the line." But even the famous Admiral Horatio

Saluting the flagship
A 17th-century Dutch states yacht (right) fires a salute to the admiral's flagship (left), possibly belonging to the popular Admiral Michiel de Ruyter. Following naval tradition, a salute usually consists of an odd number of shots. An even number denotes a death. A 21-gun salute is reserved for heads of state.

1568
Start of 80 Years War, Dutch struggle for independence from Spain

1588
Defeat of the Armada prevents invasion of England by Philip II of Spain

1628
Dutch privateer Piet Heyn succeeds in capturing Spanish silver fleet at Matanzas in northern Cuba

1652–73
Anglo-Dutch Wars: series of three wars fought for control of the English Channel and North Sea

1653
Line-of-battle tactics used at the battle of the Gabbard, between England and the United Provinces



Cat-o'-nine tails
This rope whip was used on board ships for administering corporal punishment.

1550 1580 1610 1640 1670



Musketeer's powder flask
The matchlock musket was the standard firearm of marines in the 17th century.

1572
Group of privateers, known as the Sea Beggars, capture port of Brielle (Brill) from the Spanish

1592–98
Japanese invasion of Korea thwarted by naval victories of Yi Sunshi

1628
The *Vasa*, pride of Sweden's navy, sinks on her maiden voyage

1639
Dutch under Maarten Tromp defeat Spanish fleet at battle of the Downs (French Gloire and British Warrior)

1690
War of the League of Augsburg: newly built French navy defeats Dutch and English at the battle of Beachy Head